

Ethics

Ethics and **morals** relate to “right” and “wrong” conduct. While they are sometimes used interchangeably, they are different: **ethics** refer to rules provided by an external source, e.g., codes of conduct in workplaces or principles in religions. **Morals** refer to an individual’s own principles regarding right and wrong.

	Ethics	Morals
What are they?	The rules of conduct recognized in respect to a particular class of human actions or a particular group or culture.	Principles or habits with respect to right or wrong conduct. While morals also prescribe dos and don'ts, morality is ultimately a personal compass of right and wrong.
Where do they come from?	Social system - External	Individual - Internal
Why we do it?	Because society says it is the right thing to do.	Because we believe in something being right or wrong.
Flexibility	Ethics are dependent on others for definition. They tend to be consistent within a certain context, but can vary between contexts.	Usually consistent, although can change if an individual’s beliefs change.
The "Gray"	A person strictly following Ethical Principles may not have any Morals at all. Likewise, one could violate Ethical Principles within a given system of rules in order to maintain Moral integrity.	A Moral Person although perhaps bound by a higher covenant, may choose to follow a code of ethics as it would apply to a system. "Make it fit"
Origin	Greek word "ethos" meaning “character”	Latin word "mos" meaning "custom"
Acceptability	Ethics are governed by professional and legal guidelines within a particular time and place	Morality transcends cultural norms

Normative ethics (**what should be**)

Normative ethics is the **study of ethical action**. It is the branch of ethics that investigates the set of questions that arise when considering **how one ought to act, morally speaking**. Normative ethics examines standards for the rightness and wrongness of actions. Normative ethics is **sometimes called prescriptive**

The word normative is an adjective which comes from "**norm**." In a philosophical context, the word norm usually **means standard, or rule, or principle, as opposed to what is "normal"** for people to do, that is, what they actually do. For example, the rules of arithmetic are normative in the philosophical sense, because reasoning can be assessed against these rules and judged correct or incorrect, irrespective of whether this usage is the normal usage. If everyone were to calculate 7+5 as 57, they would have made a mistake, for they would have misunderstood the rules (norms) of arithmetic. So even if this mistake were "normal," a normative appraisal would hold everyone's actual thinking to the rule which legislates how they ought to think, and judge it incorrect.

Normative ethics is concerned with moral norms. A moral norm is a norm in the sense of being a standard with which moral agents ought to comply. "Thou shall not murder" is an example of a moral norm: It is meant to guide our actions, and to the extent that people do not comply, we may be judged morally—that is, morally blamed. This is then the meaning of a moral norm.

Normative ethics has **two central concepts: The right and the morally good**. The concept of the **right is, roughly, the concept of duty, the concept of which actions we ought to perform, which it would be wrong not to perform**. The concept of the **morally good, a target of the theory of value**, or axiology (Greek: axios = worth; logos = study of), refers to morally good properties of human beings. Virtuous character traits such as **kindness, courage, and honesty** are examples of states that are generally thought to be morally good. It is worth noting here that the term "right" is usually reserved for **actions**, whereas the "morally good" is for states **of character**, including motives.

Which actions are right?

The theory of right action is an investigation and an attempt to answer the question: "**What ought I to do?**" The "ought" in this question is to be interpreted as a moral ought, and may be understood as equivalent to the question: "What is the right thing to do?" Besides the already mentioned terms, "right," "wrong," and "ought," other important normative concepts relating to action include "obligatory," "forbidden," "permissible," and "required."

Which states of character are morally good?

The second important focus of normative theory is the question of what states of character are desirable, or morally good. Here normative ethics attempts to answer the question: "**What sort of person ought I to be?**" This is called the theory of virtue, or virtue ethics. The focus of this aspect of normative ethics is character. A virtue is a morally desirable state of character such as courage.

The ultimate goal of all of this is to show how it might be possible to develop a consistent and reasonable system of moral rules which are valid for all "moral agents." Philosophers often speak of "moral agents": a moral agent is any being capable of understanding and acting upon some moral rule. Thus, it isn't simply enough to answer a moral question, like "Is abortion wrong?" - instead, normative ethics is involved with demonstrating that this and other questions can be answered with consistency and in the context of some general moral principles or rules.

In short, normative ethics addresses questions like the following:

What should be our moral obligations?
What is Right and what is Wrong?
What should be our moral values?
What is Good and what is Evil?

Descriptive Ethics (what is)

The category of descriptive ethics is the easiest to understand - *it simply involves describing how people behave and/or what sorts of moral standards they claim to follow.* Descriptive ethics incorporates research from the fields of anthropology, psychology, sociology and history as part of the process of understanding what people do or have believed about moral norms.

Anthropologists and sociologists can provide us with all sorts of information about how societies past and present have structured moral standards and how they have expected people to behave. Psychologists can study how a person's conscience develops and how that person goes about actually making moral choices in real or hypothetical situations. Descriptive ethics also studies the codes of conduct created by professional organizations to regulate the conduct of members.

Descriptive ethics is *sometimes referred to as comparative ethics because so much activity can involve comparing ethical systems: comparing the ethics of the past to the present, comparing the ethics of one society to another and comparing the ethics which people claim to follow with the actual rules of conduct which do describe their actions.*

Strictly speaking, then, descriptive ethics is not entirely a field within philosophy - rather, it is more a specialty which involves many different fields within the social sciences. It is not designed to provide guidance to people in making moral decisions, nor is it designed to evaluate the reasonableness of moral norms. Nevertheless, actual work in moral philosophy cannot proceed very far without the knowledge gained from descriptive ethics.

In short, descriptive ethics asks these two questions:

1. What do people claim as their moral norms?
2. How do people actually behave when it comes to moral problems?

Here are some examples of statements from Descriptive Ethics:

1. Most Americans think that racism is wrong.
2. Among certain cultures, there is no stigma attached to homosexuality.
3. Stanley Milgram's study found a great discrepancy between what people claimed and what they actually did.

Ethical Relativism

Relativism theorizes that **truth is different for different people**, not simply that different people *believe* different things to be true. While there are relativists in science and mathematics, ethical relativism is the most common variety of relativism. Almost everyone has heard a relativist slogan:

- What's right for you may not be what's right for me.
- What's right for my culture won't necessarily be what's right for your culture.
- No moral principles are true for all people at all times and in all places.

Ethical relativism represents the position that **there are no moral absolutes, no moral right or wrong**. This position would assert that **our morals evolve and change with social norms over a period of time**. This philosophy allows people to mutate ethically as the culture, knowledge, and technology change in society. Slavery is a good example of ethical relativism. Repeatedly the value of a human being is determined by a combination of social preferences and patterns, experience, emotions, and “rules” that seemed to bring about the most benefit.

What is ethical relativism from **a subjective view**? **Subjective ethical relativism supports the view that the truth of moral principles is relative to individuals**. Whatever you believe is right for you personally is completely up to you to determine. Subjective relativism allows you to be sovereign over the principles that dictate how you live your life.

Conventional ethical relativism supports the view that the truth of moral principles is relative to cultures. Unlike the subjective view, what is right for you as an individual is dependent upon what your particular culture believes is right for you. This view supports the concept that whatever culture says is right for you *really* is right for you. The culture or society becomes the highest authority about what is right for each individual within that society. Conventional relativism places the individual's will subordinate to the will of the cultural majority.

What is ethical relativism from an **absolute view**? The desire to have an absolute set of ethics implies an Absolute Ethics Source which can easily be deduced **as being God**. This position would be opposed to ethical relativism. Instead, the relativist excludes any religious system based on absolute morals and would condemn absolute ethics. God has the power to convey things to us that are absolute truthful and ethical. Those absolutes, however, may not be to our liking or please our subjective tastes. “*For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways,*’ declares the Lord”

Pros and Cons of Ethical Relativism

For

1. It is a pluralist and tolerant position: we should certainly be relativist about many Cultural behaviors
2. It is in strong opposition to any form of cultural chauvinism
3. Ethical values do not have to be located in some shadowy, intuited world or in the hands of a deity: they arise from our real-life interactions
4. The argument from sentience: in a world with no sentient creatures, there would be no ethical values—morality only arises with agents interacting with one another in a social context
5. “There is something conventional about any morality, so every morality really depends on a level of social acceptance.” (Pojman. Ethics 29)

Against

- a. It is self-contradictory: two mutually exclusive views can both be right. And “there are no objective truths” looks like an objective truth
- b. There is no possibility of moral action: everything must be tolerated. To intervene implies that there is some higher value
- c. All reformers—eg William Wilberforce, Rosa Parks, Christian martyrs, Jesus—must be wrong since they are going against prevailing values
- d. Disagreements about ethics don't imply an absence of objective values any more than disagreements about facts imply an absence of physics
- e. The argumentum ad Nazism: some things just seem wrong. If the Nazis had won and promoted their values across Europe, would they now be right?
- f. There do, in fact, appear to be common objective moral values: incest, truth=telling, homicide, restitution, fairness, promise=keeping, etc
- g. It is difficult to determine what constitutes a society : the Ku Klux Klan? two terrorists in a room?—conventional relativism quickly collapses into subjectivism

Consequentialism

Act **Utilitarianism is the** most common form.

Focuses on

- **pleasure and pain,**
- happiness and suffering

Utilitarianism

The Principle of Utility

- "Nature has placed mankind under the governance of two sovereign masters, pain and pleasure."
- ***the good is whatever brings the greatest happiness to the greatest number of people***
- 'Acts are right in proportion as they tend to promote pleasure and or happiness; wrong as they tend to promote the opposite of happiness

The Greatest Happiness Principle

- “The ultimate endis an existence freed as far as possible from pain, and as rich as possible in enjoyments both in point of quantity and quality’
- **‘One should always act so as to promote the greatest happiness of the greatest number’**

Utilitarian Action: A 3-Step Formula

1. On the basis of what we know, we must project consequences of each alternative option (action or omission) open to us
2. Calculate how much happiness or balance of happiness over unhappiness, is likely to be produced by anticipated consequences of action or omission
3. Select that action which, on balance, will produce the greatest amount of happiness for the greatest number of people affected

The Strengths of Utilitarianism

1. This theory specifies its goal to **increase positive value** and minimize evil. This goal on its own can hardly be disputed

- Utilitarianism has a **potential answer for most situations**, a simple action-guiding rule or principle **widely applicable**. We have a clear though demanding procedure for arriving at answers about what to do.
- Utilitarians recognise that “the path to hell is paved with good intentions” and therefore **focus moral evaluation on consequences** and not on motives the agent holds
- Utilitarianism is not just abstract “up in the clouds moralising”. It gets to the substance of morality with a material core: promote human happiness

Some Problems with Utilitarianism

- It is argumentative issue whether we should be held equally accountable for our so-called actions and omissions. It is impractical to extend the scope of responsibility to include omissions – what we could do but fail to do
- More serious **is how we determine the consequences in terms of wellbeing, happiness or pleasure**. Critics claim that persons simply choose their understanding of these ends to be achieved
- There is **no unanimous and agreed meaning to pleasures, happiness**, the wellbeing of others. This seems to cast doubt on any possible objectivity to these human goods at the heart of any utilitarianism
- Utilitarianism **could sanction immoral actions as judged by** the standards of common morality. If the most effective way to achieve a maximal utilitarian outcome (secure information to save 50 people) is to perform an immoral act (torture an innocent person) then the theory seems to say not only that the torture is permissible, but that it is morally obligatory. But this requirement of the theory seems itself immoral
- Utilitarianism demands too much on two fronts:
 - The level of skills needed is too stringent: judgement, knowledge, calculation of outcomes from actions and omissions, required imagination to envisage consequences.
 - In the interest of maximizing outcomes, it requires a violation of one’s character and integrity by expecting a level of heroic sacrifice

Deontology: The Idea of Ethical Duty

- The centrality of rules, reason and moral motives (resistance of consequentialism)
- The moral motive **for any action is to choose always out of respect for the moral law**

Duty vs. Consequences

- Kant adamantly disagreed with utilitarianism, believing it was an irresponsible theory contributing to expediency and compromises with moral evil.
- For deontologists, **consequences do not determine right and wrong**.
- The **correctness of the action matters most**, regardless of the possible benefits or harm.
- Some moral obligations are absolute regardless of the consequences.

Key features of Kantian deontology

- Unlike consequentialism, where the value of moral choices is their instrumentality, deontology finds intrinsic value in good choices
- Whether they achieve good consequences is not essential to their moral quality
- For Kant there is a domain of laws applying to our conduct, involving a nonnegotiable morality, and disclosed to us through reason
- He proposed the supreme principle of morality, the “categorical imperative”: a rule that admits no exceptions, one that is binding on all moral beings.
- He admired the will of the rational being: ‘in which the highest and unconditional good alone can be found’

How should we live?

The Categorical Imperative: Four Duties

1. Act in such a way as **you would have others act towards** you (the famous “**golden rule**”)
2. **Treat people as ends in themselves** and never solely as means to an end (people should never be simply instruments for my own ends)
3. Act so that you treat the will of every rational being as one that makes universal law (**respect for the autonomy of others**)
4. Act in such a way that you would have **all other persons act** (**rule of universality**)

Some strengths of the theory

1. Kant explains with insight how we ought to live: to be committed to a moral system of principles and rules
2. His four duties are specific enough to give guidance where needed in many circumstances of living. The theory then is practicable
3. The idea of universality is an undeniably helpful constraint on temptations to act solely out of self interest. People cannot act morally while making themselves privileged or exempt from the duty of universality
4. The argument that good consequences are never sufficient for the moral quality of an action offers fundamental challenges for utilitarian moral theory to respond

Some problems with Deontology

1. Kant's ethics lead to rigidly insensitive rules and so cannot take account of differences between cases
2. Kant identifies ethical duties that are too abstract to apply. If this is so this theory may not be action guiding.
3. Some serious criticisms are directed at Kant's moral psychology. Kant says we ought to act out of the motive of duty and not out of inclination, emotion, sentiments or feeling. In fact, because these latter elements can make us confuse feeling with moral obligations, we should be wary of them. Thus Kant seems to take a negative view on the role of emotions and claims that an action we enjoy cannot be morally worthy

Ethical and Legal issues

Ethics deals with: moral vs immoral, legal vs illegal

As a software engineer or programmer, you are obliged to make ethical decisions:

- Nature of actions: are they fair, reasonable, conscionable?
- Consequences of actions or inactions: who gains, who loses?
- consequences of actions on others: society issues

Threats to ethics:

- telecommunications, networks, Internet
- massive distributed databases
- ease of access to information
- view that stored information/knowledge are competitive weapons

Some ethics guidelines

- William Allen (Boeing's CEO for 14 years)
 - Do not be afraid to admit that you don't know.
 - Be definite - tell it like it is.
 - Try to promote honest feelings toward the company.
 - Don't talk too much... let others talk.

- Be considerate of your associates' views.
 - Above all, be human - keep your sense of humour and learn to relax
- ACM Code of Ethics (extracts)
 - General Moral Imperatives
 - honour property rights including copyrights and patents
 - respect the privacy of others
 - honor confidentiality
 - Professional responsibilities
 - give comprehensive evaluations of computer systems and their impact, with emphasis on possible risks
 - improve public understanding of computing and its consequences
 - Organizational Leadership Imperatives
 - acknowledge and support ethical uses of computing systems
 - support policies that protect the dignity of users and others affected by computing systems